

THROUGH TIME, TASTE AND TRANQUILITY

From spice-scented markets and sea-facing sanctuaries to misty hill trails and ancient rituals, North Kerala reveals a soulful, lesser-known side of God's Own Country

By Ishani Nandi

It all begins, as it often does in Kerala, with people around a table, conversation and food. At Hotel Jineesh, a small, bare-bones eatery in Chaliyam, my order arrives on a steel plate filled to the brim and placed on a rough-hewn, wooden table. Three men, already seated, see mid-chat that there's no room elsewhere, and wave us over to settle next to them. I slide my plastic stool forward to this Malabar classic: *kallumakkaya*—freshly harvested mussels simmering in a light gravy mix of its own juices, coconut slivers and fragrant spices—and a thick slice of pathri, a golden-fried, rice-flour roundel. I dig in as a fresh batch of batter-fried bananas are carried out by a sari-clad woman, whose face brightens into a smile as hungry locals trickle in, eager to start the day right.

If Kerala's south were a monsoon downpour, the north would be its petrichor. Unlike its well-publicised southern sibling, North Kerala remains largely untouched by the stampede of mass tourism, inviting you in with the promise of raw landscapes, languid rhythms and a storied history.